

US hiring slows as families face rising prices

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-03 3 min read

US **employers** added 29,000 jobs in September, fewer than economists expected. The **unemployment** rate rose from 4.1 percent in August to 4.2 percent. This rate measures the share of people in the labor force who are without work and looking for a job.

The report matters to families because jobs provide **income** to pay for food, housing and other needs. But one month's figures do not tell the whole story.

Beth Hammack, president of the Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland, told PBS NewsHour that monthly job numbers can change a lot. She said **employers** added an average of 41,000 jobs each month over the past year. She said **unemployment** had stayed low and fairly **steady**, while recognizing that losing a job can be painful.

Hammack's bigger concern is **inflation**. **Inflation** means prices are rising overall. If pay grows more slowly than prices, a family's money buys less.

She said people she met in Northeast Ohio described difficult choices about paying for food, fuel and rent. Some were relying more on **credit**, or borrowed money.

The Federal Reserve works toward both strong employment and stable prices. Its **inflation** goal is 2 percent. Hammack said bringing **inflation** back to that goal remains important. The hiring report arrives a month before the US midterm elections.

Word Treasure

employers -- People or organizations that hire people to work.

unemployment -- Being without a job while looking for work.

income -- Money a person receives, such as pay from a job.

inflation -- An overall rise in prices.

credit -- Borrowed money that must be paid back.

steady -- Changing very little over time.

Background you need

The unemployment rate measures the share of people in the labor force who are without work and looking for a job.

When prices rise faster than pay, a family's money buys less.

The Federal Reserve works toward strong employment and stable prices.

Break it down

Opens with September job growth and the change in unemployment.

Explains why jobs matter to families and why one month's figures are limited.

Presents Hammack's view of job trends over the past year.

Defines inflation and describes the bill choices people reported to Hammack.

Ends with the Federal Reserve's inflation goal and the election timing.

Why it matters

Jobs help families pay for everyday needs. Rising prices can make those needs harder to afford when pay does not keep up.

Test what you remember

1. How many jobs did US employers add in September?
 - (A) 29,000 jobs
 - (B) 12,000 jobs
 - (C) 41,000 jobs
 - (D) 60,000 jobs
2. How did the unemployment rate change from August to September?
 - (A) It stayed at 4.1 percent.
 - (B) It fell from 4.2 to 4.1 percent.
 - (C) It rose from 4.1 to 4.2 percent.
 - (D) It stayed at 4.2 percent.
3. Why did Hammack say one month's job figures do not tell the whole story?
 - (A) Monthly job numbers describe only Ohio.
 - (B) Monthly job numbers can change a lot.
 - (C) Monthly job numbers count only teachers.
 - (D) Monthly job numbers measure food prices.
4. What does inflation mean in the article?
 - (A) Savings are rising overall.
 - (B) Prices are rising overall.
 - (C) Pay is rising overall.
 - (D) Hiring is rising overall.
5. Where did Hammack meet people who described difficult choices about bills?
 - (A) In Northeast Texas
 - (B) In Southern Florida
 - (C) In Southern California
 - (D) In Northeast Ohio
6. What is the Federal Reserve's inflation goal?
 - (A) 4.2 percent
 - (B) 2 percent
 - (C) 5.5 percent
 - (D) 4.1 percent

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Beth Hammack:** She said monthly job figures can vary and unemployment had stayed low and fairly steady. Her bigger concern was bringing inflation back to the Federal Reserve's 2 percent goal.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):